



YEMEN

Capital city: San'a**Area:** 203,850 sq miles (527,970 sq km)**Population:** 20,000,000**Official language:** Arabic**Major religions:** Muslim 97%, other 3%**Government:** Multiparty democracy**Currency:** Yemeni rial**Adult literacy rate:** 49%**Life expectancy:** 57 years**People per doctor:** 5,000**Televisions:** 29 per 1,000 people

YEMEN

THE COUNTRY OF YEMEN was formed in 1990 when North and South Yemen were reunited. Yemen lies at the southern tip of the Arabian Peninsula. It is more fertile than other Middle Eastern countries, with good farmland in the western highlands where there is regular rainfall. The coast and mountains of the east are hot, dry, and barren. Yemen is a poorer, less developed country than its neighbors. It is hoped that oil reserves, discovered in the 1980s, may help increase its prosperity in the future.



THE PORT OF ADEN

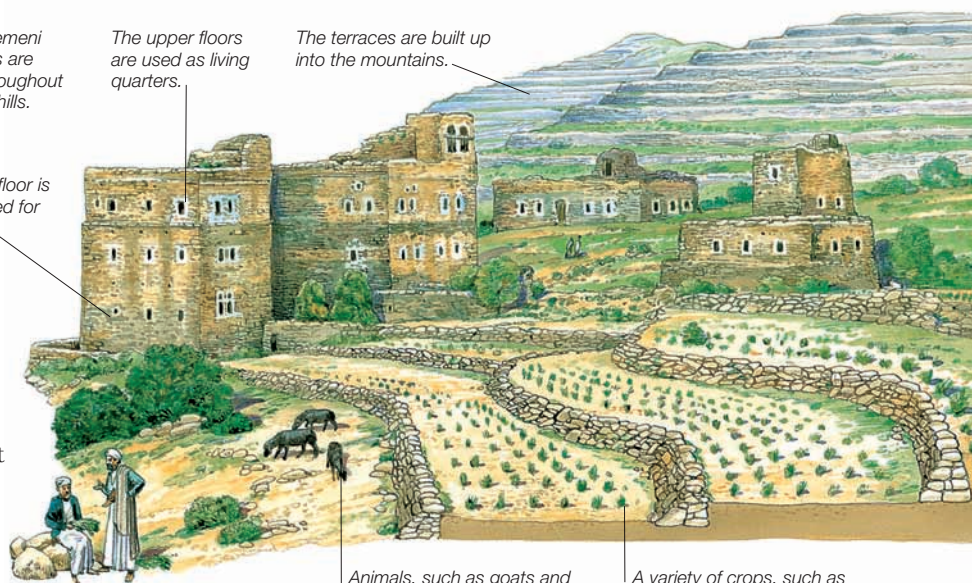
Aden is one of the biggest cities in Yemen and the country's main port. Because of its location on the Gulf of Aden, it has been the region's chief trading city since ancient times. Today, it is an important industrial center, with a huge oil refinery, factories, and an international airport.

Traditional Yemeni tower houses are scattered throughout the terraced hills.

The upper floors are used as living quarters.

The terraces are built up into the mountains.

The first floor is often used for storage.



Animals, such as goats and sheep, are kept on the ground floor of a house.

A variety of crops, such as coffee and cotton, are grown on the Yemeni terraces.

YEMENI TERRACES

In many places the mountain slopes of Yemen are terraced to provide extra space for crops. Some terraces are more than 1,300 years old. About half of Yemeni workers are farmers. They grow cereal crops, such as wheat and sorghum, along with citrus fruits and dates, and raise sheep, goats, and cattle. Coffee and cotton are grown mainly for export.

Coffee is often served in traditional Bedouin pots.



COFFEE AND QAT

Coffee is thought to have originated as a drink in Yemen, and the country produces some of the world's finest quality beans. Yemen is also famous for a plant called *qat*.

Its leaves contain a mild drug and are often chewed. *Qat* parties are an important part of Yemeni social life.



Tribal men often wear a ceremonial dagger, or *jambiya*, strapped to the waist.

SAN'A

San'a, the capital of Yemen, is an ancient city famous for its traditional Yemeni-style architecture. In the old city you can still see clusters of 400-year-old multistory mud and brick tower houses, their outer walls often decorated with friezes. An international conservation effort has been launched to protect this unique city and preserve its buildings for the future.



TRIBAL SOCIETY

Most Yemeni people are Muslim Arabs belonging to various tribal groups. Each tribe elects a sheik as its leader and has its own customs, costumes, and folklore. Within a tribe, people live in large, closely knit, extended families. Several generations of the same family usually share the same house. The tribal tradition is particularly strong in northern Yemen.

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